



Title pursuit: After leading India to its maiden ODI World Cup title in 2025, Harmanpreet Kaur now sets her sights on another crown with the T20 World Cup around the corner. NIRMAL HARINDRAN

A series that arrives with context attached

India's growing stability meets South Africa's search for closure in a five-match series that could shape their **T20 World Cup trajectories.**

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Five months ago, on the now hallowed turf of the D.Y. Patil Stadium, India and South Africa came face to face, with a shiny ICC ODI World Cup trophy propped between them. An epic final ensued, with momentum swinging wildly between the two challengers. Eventually, India entered a vortex of glory, one unexplored before, with a sea of blue chanting as it ascended

the 50-over throne. The Proteas, meanwhile, were resigned to a familiar loop of despair.

In 2023, Meg Lanning's Australia denied the side World T20 glory in front of a heartbroken home crowd. In 2024, it was Sophie Devine's White Ferns who blew the South Africans away into the Emirati desert. A third heartbreak, this time on Indian soil, can do one of two things: birth an almost vengeful pursuit of triumph or break the progress made so far. When the T20 World Cup comes around in June, this time in England,

the ecosystem will have its answers.

A credible dress rehearsal is on the cards when Harmanpreet Kaur and Co. fly to South Africa for a five-match T20I series starting April 17. **This is the last bilateral series the Proteas will play before boarding the flight to England, leaving a 47-day gap before they take the field again in the World Cup.** India, meanwhile, has squeezed in a T20I series against England, three matches that will aid acclimatisation and offer a more realistic picture of form and adaptability to conditions.